

Anxiety and depression

Anxiety and depression are the two most common forms of mental illness. These conditions last longer and are more severe than feeling worried or sad about something.

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◀ 84–85 Emotions

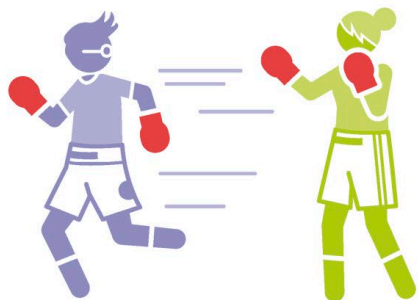
◀ 92–93 Stress

Panic attacks and phobias

96–97 ▶

Anxiety

Feeling anxious is a normal response to any type of stress. It describes the thoughts and feelings associated with being worried or afraid. Although it usually feels unpleasant, anxiety is related to the “fight or flight” response, a biological reaction to life-threatening situations that humans, like all other animals, have in order to cope with danger.



◀ Fight or flight

When threatened, the body releases hormones that prepare it to fight or flee. The heart beats faster and the brain becomes more alert.

When anxiety is a problem

For some people, however, these anxious feelings do not go away once the stressful event is over. If feelings of anxiety are very strong or overwhelming, last for a long time, or have an impact on their lifestyle, a teen's anxiety may have become unmanageable.



▷ Getting help

If anxious feelings start to restrict a teen's lifestyle, it's best to see a doctor.

Managing anxiety and depression

Just as there are ways to keep the body healthy, there are many different steps teens can take to keep their minds healthy, too:

Mindfulness

Yoga and meditation can teach teens to focus on the present.



Go outside

Being outside in nature can help elevate a teen's mood.



Friends and family

Connecting with others is a great way to improve mental well-being.



Exercise and sports

Exercise causes the brain to release endorphins, a natural antidepressant.



Be creative

Making things and doing creative or crafty activities boosts mood and gives a sense of satisfaction.



Stay healthy

An active, healthy lifestyle helps keep the mind healthy and interested, too.

